infection home. But as of this moment, the country needed them and they pushed back their fears and stood on the frontline in service of our country.

While in no uncertain way was this perceived as a one-off event, it did raise immediate crucial questions. Did we need to shut down schools nationwide to protect our children? What if kids at the birthday party caught the infection? How would the virus play out on their health? Would it be fatal? Just the thought of these scenarios was shuddering and SOPs needed to be framed to protect our vulnerable populations on priority.

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Even as regional authorities were busy putting teams in place to smoothen out tracing, testing and isolating procedures, Dr V.K. Paul and Prof. K. VijayRaghavan were meeting frequently in Delhi in NITI Aayog to closely track the developments and research solutions. They had been closely observing the devastation that the virus was causing in the countries in its grip. Based on fatality and doubling rates, the need of the hour was to do some mathematical modelling in order to provide various estimates of the spread in India. Their thinking was to investigate different mathematical scenarios, pre-empt and prevent the worst outcomes as much as we can. The best analogy that Prof. VijayRaghavan later used to explain why accurate mathematical modelling was important at that point in time for India was one comparing the spread of the virus to a growing tree: ‘Modelling would be able to tell us in which direction and how much the virus would grow if it was left unchecked versus if preventative measures were taken. It would give us a very fair idea of where and how much that tree would need to be trimmed.’ A range of possibilities would have to be presented to the prime minister and the principal secretary for urgent, important restrictions to be put in place.

There were several expert modelling groups across the globe as well as in India. The agreement between the two gentlemen was to get as many opinions and as much meaningful data as quickly as possible. After about a fortnight of reaching out to about 10 such groups, calling them in for meetings or holding meetings with them virtually, a consensus was reached on which seemed to be the most accurate model. Immediately after, having seen very grim numbers, they requested time from the principal secretary to present their findings.